through trade. As a result by the 6th century BC (BCE), Greece turned into a network of City-States. **Acropolis**, a fortified city of ancient Greeks on a hill in Athens, is an illustrative example of their advancement. Though the City-States fought each other they were bound together by trade, by a common alphabet, similar religious practices, and festivals. The illustrious example for the last one was the Olympic festival of sports and games.



Acropolis

The ruling class in Greece controlled the land. Slaves cultivated the land. Greek writers and philosophers saw the ownership of slaves as essential to a civilized life. Aristotle compared the master and slave relationship to that of husband and wife, and father and children.

Greeks' Victory over Persians

King Darius (BC (BCE) 550–486), who was heading a great empire in Persia, decided to conquer the Greek City-States. The first Persian attack on Greece failed. This was due to the fact that Persian army suffered from disease and lack of food during its march. Therefore, in planning the second attack, the Persians avoided the land route and came by sea. The Greeks or Hellenes, fought patriotically and defeated the Persian army at Marathon in 490 BC (BCE). Xerxes, King Darius' successor conducted another expedition. Joined by Spartans this time, the Athenians persisted in their resistance and in the final battle fought in Salamis, Persian ships were destroyed. Disheartened Xerxes returned to Persia without achieving his end.

"Democracy" in Hellenic Greece

When the Greek City-States first emerged, they still carried the legacy of the past. The rulers came from lines of traditional chieftains. Those who grew rich from the expansion of trade resented the privileges enjoyed by the old ruling families. Yet the Age of Tyrants 6th century to 4th century BC (BCE) proved to be a period of urban development, with new buildings and enormous temples such as **Olympian Zeus** at Athens.

Athenian Democracy

In Athens, the pressure from below resulted in the replacement of both oligarchy and tyranny by "democracy." The law-making power in Athens was vested in an assembly open to all freemen. Judges and lower officials were chosen by lots. This arrangement was resented by the upper classes who considered democracy to be the rule of the mob.

The Persian danger had united the Greeks. When this danger was removed, they started quarrelling again. The history of many Greek city-states was one of continual struggles by the rich landowners against "democracy". The only exception was Athens, where "democracy' survived for about 200 years.

The word '**democracy**', literally means "rule of the people". In reality it excluded slaves, women, and non-residents known as metics (traders and craftsmen).

Pericles (461–429 BC (BCE)

Athens had a great leader, Pericles, who held power for thirty years. During his rule, **Athens** and **Sparta** were continuously at war with each

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